

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 102 “THE ONENESS OF GOD”

Part One:
The Biblical Revelation of God’s Unity

The Importance of the Doctrine of God

Every true discipleship journey begins with a right understanding of who God is. If God is misunderstood, everything that follows like salvation, worship, prayer, ministry, and even morality becomes distorted. The doctrine of the Oneness of God is therefore not a peripheral teaching but a foundational revelation upon which the entire Christian faith rests.

The Bible does not begin by proving God’s existence; it begins by revealing God’s identity. From Genesis to Revelation, Scripture consistently presents God as one singular, indivisible, unique, and incomparable. This oneness is not merely numerical; it speaks of God’s being, essence, and self-existence.

In a world filled with polytheism, idolatry, and divided spiritual loyalties, the biblical revelation of God’s oneness establishes clarity, authority, and exclusive devotion.

Old T. Witness to the Oneness of God

The doctrine of God’s oneness is rooted firmly in the Old Testament. Israel’s faith was distinguished from surrounding nations precisely because it affirmed the existence of one true God in contrast to the many gods of pagan cultures.

The clearest declaration of this truth is found in the **Shema. Shema is the Israel’s central confession of faith:**

“Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD” (Deuteronomy 6:4).

This statement is a divine proclamation. It affirms that Yahweh alone is God: not one among many, not part of a divine hierarchy, and not a composite of separate beings. He is one in essence, one in will, and one in authority.

Throughout the Old Testament, God repeatedly distinguishes Himself from idols by emphasizing His uniqueness. He declares, *“I am the LORD, and there is none else, there is no God beside me”* (Isaiah 45:5). Such statements leave no room for multiple divine persons functioning as separate centers of consciousness. God alone speaks, acts, creates, redeems, judges, and saves.

This oneness also establishes God’s exclusivity in worship. Because there is only one true God, divided allegiance is spiritual adultery. Israel’s repeated failures often stemmed not from denying God outright but from attempting to combine devotion to Yahweh with other gods. Scripture consistently condemns this mixture.

The Nature of God’s Oneness

God's oneness is not the same as created oneness. Created beings can be one in agreement, purpose, or unity, but they remain numerically distinct. Like a couple (Two different people, man and woman coming together in agreement and purpose) in marriage. God's oneness, however, is ontological: it concerns His very being. He is not composed of parts, persons, or divisions. He is indivisible spirit.

This is why Scripture insists that God is simple, not complex. He does not have parts that can be separated or persons that can be independently addressed. His attributes: holiness, love, power, wisdom are not segments of Him; they are expressions of His one, unified essence.

Understanding this guards you from imagining God in human categories. God is not a committee, a family of divine persons, or a cooperative partnership. He is one sovereign Lord whose self-revelation unfolds in different ways across redemptive history, yet whose being remains undivided.

New T. Continuity of God's Oneness

The New Testament does not abandon the Old Testament revelation of God's oneness; it confirms and deepens it. Jesus Himself affirmed the **Shema** when questioned about the greatest commandment. He began by saying, "*Hear, O Israel; The Lord our God is one Lord*" (Mark 12:29). This affirmation is critical. Jesus did not introduce a new doctrine of God; He stood firmly within Israel's monotheistic faith.

The apostles likewise upheld this truth. Paul wrote, "*There is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus*" (1 Timothy 2:5). This statement affirms both the oneness of God and the mediatorial role of Christ without dividing God into separate divine beings.

James echoed the same conviction when he wrote, "*Thou believest that there is one God; thou doest well*" (James 2:19). The oneness of God was not debated in the early church; it was assumed.

The revelation of Jesus Christ does not contradict God's oneness; it reveals God in manifestation. The New Testament presents Jesus not as a second divine person alongside God, but as God made known in human form. Scripture declares that God was manifest in the flesh, not joined to flesh as a separate being, but revealed within it.

Jesus consistently spoke of God as one, even while revealing His unique relationship with the Father. His statements emphasize unity, not separation. When He said, "*I and my Father are one*," He was not introducing plurality of divine beings but affirming shared identity and essence.

The fullness of God dwelling in Christ does not require God to be divided; it requires God to be present. Just as God filled the temple without being confined by it, He dwelt fully in Christ without ceasing to be one.

The doctrine of God's oneness has direct implications for salvation. If God is one, then salvation is not accomplished by negotiation between divine persons but by the singular saving action of God Himself. Scripture repeatedly declares that God alone

saves.

This truth magnifies grace. Salvation flows from God's own initiative, power, and mercy. The same God who created is the God who redeems. The same Lord who judges sin is the One who forgives it. There is no division of will within God concerning salvation.

Understanding this also preserves the believer's confidence. Faith is not placed in a system of divine relationships but in the one Lord who saves completely.

Part Two: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit in the Revelation of the One God

Understanding Biblical Language About God

One of the main reasons confusion arises around the doctrine of God is a failure to distinguish between God's being and God's self-revelation. Scripture speaks of God in various ways: as Father, as Son, and as Holy Spirit; yet never presents these as three separate gods or independent divine beings. Rather, these terms describe how the one God relates, reveals Himself, and works in redemption.

The Bible does not use philosophical categories to explain God. It uses relational and functional language. When Scripture speaks of God as Father, it emphasizes origin, authority, care, and relationship. When it speaks of the Son, it reveals God manifested in humanity for redemption. When it speaks of the Holy Spirit, it points to God active, present, and working within creation and believers.

These are not divisions within God but expressions of the one God engaging with His world.

God as Father

The title "Father" does not mean that God is one person among others in a divine family. In Scripture, "Father" primarily speaks of God as source, initiator, and sovereign origin of all things. God is Father because all things proceed from Him, and because He relates to His people in covenantal love and authority.

In the OT, God is repeatedly called Father (around 10 - 15 mentions), long before the incarnation of Christ. This shows that Fatherhood is not dependent on the Son as a separate divine person but is intrinsic to God's relationship with creation and His people.

When Jesus addressed God as Father, He was not introducing a new deity but revealing the relational nearness of the one God. He brought clarity to what had always been true: that the one God is not distant, but relational and loving.

God Revealed in the Son

The term “Son” does not describe a second divine being but refers to God manifested in flesh (the expression of Godhead). The Sonship of Christ begins in time, not eternity. Scripture never speaks of an “eternally begotten Son” in biblical language; instead, it presents the Son as the result of God entering human history.

Jesus was fully human and fully divine, not because two persons were joined, but because God Himself took on humanity. **The Son reveals God in a way that humanity could see, hear, and touch.** As Scripture declares, the invisible God made Himself visible (Colossians 1:5).

This is why Jesus could say that whoever had seen Him had seen the Father (John 14:9). He did not point away from Himself to another divine being; He revealed God through His own person. The Son is not God alongside God; the Son is God expressed in human form for redemption.

The prayers of Jesus, His submission, and His obedience are not conversations between divine persons but expressions of genuine humanity relating to God. As man, Jesus prayed. As God, He answered prayer. This mystery does not divide God; it magnifies the incarnation.

God as the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit is not a separate divine person but God in active presence and power. Throughout Scripture, the Spirit of God is God Himself at work: creating, empowering, regenerating, sanctifying, and indwelling.

The Spirit is called the Spirit of God, the Spirit of the Lord, and the Spirit of Christ, not because these are different spirits, but because the one God operates consistently in unity. When believers receive the Holy Spirit, they are not receiving a different God from the Father or the Son; they are receiving the same God dwelling within them (1 Corinthians 3:17–18, Romans 8:9–10, Galatians 4:6)

The Spirit does not speak independently of God’s will (John 16:13), nor act separately from Christ’s work. The Spirit applies what God has accomplished in Christ to the believer’s life. This maintains divine unity while explaining divine activity.

Why Scripture Uses Distinct Titles

Scripture uses different titles because God’s work unfolds in stages of revelation. Creation, redemption, and indwelling are not separate acts by different divine agents; they are distinct works of the one God.

God is Father in creation and covenant.

God is Son in redemption and revelation.

God is Spirit in regeneration and empowerment.

These distinctions are functional, not personal divisions within God’s being. They help us understand what God does without fragmenting who God is.

Common Misunderstandings and Doctrinal Errors

One common error is reading later philosophical frameworks back into Scripture. When biblical terms are interpreted through post-biblical categories, God is unintentionally divided into separate centers of consciousness. This creates conceptual tension not found in Scripture itself.

Another error is treating relational language as ontological division. When Jesus speaks to the Father, He is not proving plurality of divine beings; He is expressing real human dependence upon God. To deny this humanity is to deny the incarnation itself.

A further mistake is confusing distinction with separation. Scripture clearly distinguishes Father, Son, and Spirit in operation, but it never separates them into independent gods or persons acting apart from one another.

Understanding God's oneness shapes worship profoundly. Worship becomes undivided, focused, and intimate. Prayer is not directed through layers of divine hierarchy but offered directly to the one God who saves, hears, and responds.

This doctrine also shapes discipleship. Loyalty becomes singular. Devotion becomes whole. There is no room for spiritual compartmentalization when God is known as one Lord over every area of life.

Part Three: Biblical Language, Salvation, Worship, and Pastoral Balance

The Oneness of God and the Language of Salvation

Scripture consistently presents salvation as the work of one saving God, not a cooperative effort between divine persons. This emphasis is deliberate and repeated across both Testaments.

God declares plainly:

"I, even I, am the LORD; and beside me there is no saviour" (Isaiah 43:11).

Again He says,

"There is no God else beside me; a just God and a Saviour; there is none beside me" (Isaiah 45:21).

These declarations are not poetic exaggerations. They are doctrinal assertions. If God alone is Savior, then redemption must be understood as God Himself acting to save, not God delegating salvation to another divine being.

The New Testament affirms this continuity. Paul writes,

"God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself" (2 Corinthians 5:19).

Notice carefully: God was not reconciled to the world by Christ; God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself. This preserves divine unity while explaining the incarnation.

Likewise, Titus 2:13 speaks of *“the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ,”* not separating them, but identifying Jesus as the visible revelation of the one saving God.

Jesus Christ as the Full Revelation of the One God

The New Testament repeatedly testifies that Jesus is the complete and final revelation of God, not a partial or secondary expression.

John writes,

“No man hath seen God at any time; the only begotten Son... hath declared him” (John 1:18).

Paul affirms,

“In him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily” (Colossians 2:9).

The word fulness is critical. Scripture does not say part of God dwells in Christ, but all the fullness. If the fullness of God dwells bodily in Christ, then God is not divided elsewhere. Christ is not one person among others; He is God made known.

Jesus Himself testified to this unity when He said, *“He that hath seen me hath seen the Father”* (John 14:9).

He did not say, “He has seen someone similar to the Father,” but that seeing Him was seeing the Father revealed.

This explains why Jesus could also say,

“I and my Father are one” (John 10:30).

The Jews understood the implication clearly, responding that He made Himself God. Their reaction shows that Jesus’ claim was not symbolic unity of purpose alone, but a claim to divine identity.

The Holy Spirit as God in Active Presence

Scripture presents the Holy Spirit not as another God or separate divine person, but as God Himself in action and presence.

In Genesis 1:2, the Spirit of God moves over the waters, God actively creating.

In Psalm 139:7, David equates the Spirit’s presence with God’s presence:

“Whither shall I go from thy spirit? or whither shall I flee from thy presence?”

The Spirit is not someone other than God; He is God present.

Paul further clarifies this unity when he writes: *“Now the Lord is that Spirit”* (2 Corinthians 3:17).

This is not metaphorical language. It is theological identity.

The Spirit is also called:

- the Spirit of God (Romans 8:9)

- the Spirit of Christ (Romans 8:9)
- the Spirit of Jesus Christ (Philippians 1:19).

Scripture does not multiply spirits; it identifies one divine Spirit operating consistently as God Himself.

Baptism and the Oneness of God

Baptism in the NT. consistently reflects the oneness of God revealed in Christ.

Jesus commanded baptism “in the name” singular “of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost” (Matthew 28:19). Scripture does not say “names,” but name, indicating one divine identity revealed in different ways.

The apostles understood this clearly. Every recorded baptism in Acts is administered in the name of Jesus Christ:

- Acts 2:38
- Acts 8:16
- Acts 10:48
- Acts 19:5

This is not contradiction; it is interpretation. The apostles recognized that the one name in which God is fully revealed and savingly known is Jesus, for “*there is none other name under heaven given among men, whereby we must be saved*” (Acts 4:12).

Prayer, Worship, and the Oneness of God

Because God is one, worship in Scripture is undivided. Jesus taught His disciples to pray to the Father, not because the Father is separate from Him, but because prayer expresses human dependence upon God.

At the same time, Jesus received worship (Matthew 14:33; John 20:28), forgave sins (Mark 2:5–7), and exercised divine authority: actions reserved for God alone. Scripture does not resolve this by dividing God, but by revealing God in Christ.

True worship, therefore, is not confused or fragmented. It is directed to the one Lord revealed fully in Jesus Christ, through the indwelling Spirit because worship is acknowledging what God has done, what He’s doing, what He will do and who He is.

Balance

The doctrine of the oneness of God must be taught with clarity and humility. Scripture warns against both ignorance and speculation.

Paul exhorts believers to “*hold fast the form of sound words*” (2 Timothy 1:13). Sound doctrine protects the church from confusion and preserves the simplicity of faith.

At the same time, doctrine must lead to devotion. Knowing that God is one calls the believer to wholehearted love, as Jesus reaffirmed:

“*Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with*

all thy mind, and with all thy strength” (Mark 12:30).

Divided concepts of God often lead to divided devotion. Biblical oneness restores unity in worship, faith, and obedience.

Concluding Summary

Scripture reveals one God: indivisible, sovereign, and unique. This one God has made Himself known as Father in creation, as Son in redemption, and as Holy Spirit in indwelling power. These are not separate divine persons, but one God revealed and active in different ways according to His saving purpose.

The Oneness of God safeguards the unity of salvation, the clarity of worship, and the believer’s confidence in God’s saving work. It preserves the biblical confession:

“One Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all” (Ephesians 4:5–6).

Signed:

By Discp. Samuel Ojo

EDC Rector